Christina Chance

Community-Informed NLP · Algorithmic Fairness & Ethics
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EDUCATION

University of California at Los Angeles 2022 – Expected June 2027
Ph.D. in Computer Science (M.S. awarded 2024)
Eugene V. Cota-Robles Fellow, GEM Fellow.
Advisor: Prof. Kai-Wei Chang
Dissertation Title: *Whose Ground Truth? Diagnosing Where Language Technologies Fail the Communities They Act On*

Emory University 2018 – 2022
B.S. in Computer Science and Mathematics, minor in Physics
Magna Cum Laude.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

My research asks how language technologies can support **cultural pluralism**. I develop computational methods to **model, evaluate, and audit** these systems under social and linguistic variation, treating disagreement, dialect, and context as **signal to model rather than noise to resolve**. I study how models represent differences in human judgment, how dominant linguistic norms shape model behavior, and what evidence is needed to show that a system works reliably for the people it affects. My work spans three directions, **community-grounded models for subjective language**, **preserving linguistic, identity, and social norm variation**, and **governing responsible deployment in high-stakes domains**. I combine natural language processing with computational social science and digital ethnography to make these differences measurable and consequential to system design. Looking forward, my lab will build modeling frameworks, methods, and tools that let language technologies serve the full range of communities they reach, grounded in interdisciplinary collaboration.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Graduate Student Researcher Los Angeles, CA
University of California Los Angeles | UCLA Natural Language Processing Lab
PI: Prof. Kai-Wei Chang Sept. 2022 – Present

- ⋆ Build and release annotated corpora of dialect and reclaimed language, and fine-tune large language models to detect and classify hate speech and toxicity across Black, LGBTQIA+, and women's communities.
- ⋆ Develop methods to characterize how content moderation and language technologies fail marginalized individuals, auditing where cultural pluralism collapses under social and linguistic variation.
- ⋆ Served as lab social chair for three years, planning lab retreats, dinners, and social events to build community across the group.

University of California Los Angeles | Health Equity Working Group
PIs: Prof. Vickie Mays and Prof. Susan Cochran Sept. 2023 – Present

- ⋆ Applied statistical analysis and word embedding analysis to suicide death narratives in the National Violent Death Reporting System, characterizing the completeness and complexity of the records, leveraging existing APIs to process the data at scale.
- ⋆ Measured syntactic complexity and performed scope identification to surface where narratives are uncertain, incomplete, or missing information.

University of California Los Angeles | The BioCritical Studies Lab | PI: Prof. Terence Keel Sept. 2023 – Sept. 2025

- ⋆ Adapted an existing forensic autopsy annotation schema into a framework for automation, targeting deaths of incarcerated people.

- ⋆ Evaluated language model performance against validated data to test the feasibility of automating the annotation scheme.
- ⋆ Translated CS and NLP concepts for sociology and African American Studies collaborators, grounding the work in context, stakeholders, and community.

Research Intern San Jose, CA
Adobe Research | Document Intelligence | advised by Jennifer Healey June 2025 – Sept. 2025

- ⋆ Interned on the Document Intelligence team, which combines language understanding and document analysis to unlock the information inside documents. Identified recommendation skew in automated recommender systems, where certain products are never surfaced to specific demographic groups, and designed an approach to address it.
- ⋆ Developed a probabilistic persona generation method ("surprising personas") to increase recommendation diversity, identified patterns of preference-based bias in the context of recommendations, then evaluated and validated the method through a 977-participant survey.

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Publications

[1] **Research Domain Criteria and Deaths by Suicide in the National Violent Death Reporting System**
Susan D. Cochran, **Christina Chance**, Alina Arseniev-Koehler, Bruce Cuthbert, and Vickie M. Mays
JAMA Network Open 9.3 (Mar. 2026), e264024.

[2] **Measuring Narrative Complexity Among Suicide Deaths in the National Violent Death Reporting System (2003–2021 NVDRS)**
Christina Chance, Alina Arseniev-Koehler, Vickie M. Mays, Kai-Wei Chang, and Susan D. Cochran
Information 16.11 (2025).

[3] **An Analysis of Large Language Models for African American English Speaking Children's Oral Language Assessment**
Alexander Johnson, **Christina Chance**, Kaycee Stiemke, Hariram Veeramani, Natarajan Balaji Shankar, and Abeer Alwan
Journal of Black Excellence in Engineering, Science, & Technology 1 (Dec. 2023).

Peer-Reviewed Conference Publications

[4] **No Convo! The Illusion of Reliability in Online Toxicity Detection**
Rachita Rajesh, **Christina Chance**, Ashima Suvarna, Kai-Wei Chang, and Saadia Gabriel
Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: IJCNLP-AACL 2026. Ed. by Yue Zhang, Ruifeng Xu, Ayu Purwarianti, Tong Rong, and Jun Suzuki. Hengqin, China: Association for Computational Linguistics, Nov. 2026, pp. 4050–4072.

[5] **Re-imagining Virtual Communities: Ethical Guidelines for Studying Black Twitter**
Christina Chance and Kai-Wei Chang
Proceedings of the AAAI/ACM Conference on AI, Ethics, and Society 8.1 (Oct. 2025), pp. 541–553.

[6] **Leveraging Large Language Models and Topic Modeling for Toxicity Classification**
Haniyeh Ehsani Oskouie, **Christina Chance**, Claire Huang, Margaret Capetz, Elizabeth Eyeson, and Majid Sarrafzadeh
2025 International Conference on Computing, Networking and Communications (ICNC). 2025, pp. 123–127.

[7] **ModelCitizens: Representing Community Voices in Online Safety**
Ashima Suvarna, **Christina Chance**, Karolina Naranjo, Hamid Palangi, Sophie Hao, Thomas Hartvigsen, and Saadia Gabriel
Proceedings of the 2025 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing. Suzhou, China: Association for Computational Linguistics, Nov. 2025, pp. 30850–30866.

[8] **CORAAL QA: A Dataset and Framework for Open Domain Spontaneous Speech Question Answering from Long Audio Files**
Natarajan Balaji Shankar, Alexander Johnson, **Christina Chance**, Hariram Veeramani, and Abeer Alwan
ICASSP 2024 - 2024 IEEE International Conference on Acoustics, Speech and Signal Processing (ICASSP). 2024, pp. 13371–13375.

Under Review

[9] **Policy Over Purpose: Auditing LLM Content Moderation of Reclaimed Slur Usage**
Christina Chance and Kai-Wei Chang. 2026.

[10] **IYKYK (But AI Doesn't): Automated Content Moderation Does Not Capture Communities' Heterogeneous Attitudes Towards Reclaimed Language**
Christina Chance, Rebecca Pattichis, Arjun Subramonian, James He, Shruti Narayanan, Saadia Gabriel, and Kai-Wei Chang. 2026.

[11] **Tradeoffs in Automating the Annotation of In-Custody Death Records with Large Language Models**
Christina Chance, Grace Sosa, Kai-Wei Chang, and Terence Keel. 2026.

[12] **Reinforcing Stereotypes of Anger: Emotion AI on African American Vernacular English**
Rebecca Dorn, **Christina Chance**, Casandra Rusti, Charles Bickham Jr., Kai-Wei Chang, Fred Morstatter, and Kristina Lerman. 2025.

Workshop Papers, Extended Abstracts, & Preprints

[13] **Surprising Personas: Persona Sets with Controllably Unexpected Features**
Christina Chance and Jennifer Healey
Proceedings of the Extended Abstracts of the 2026 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems. CHI EA '26. Association for Computing Machinery, 2026.

[14] **Will the Prince Get True Love's Kiss? On the Model Sensitivity to Gender Perturbation over Fairytale Texts**
Christina Chance, Da Yin, Dakuo Wang, and Kai-Wei Chang
Proceedings of the 5th Workshop on Trustworthy NLP (TrustNLP 2025). Albuquerque, New Mexico: Association for Computational Linguistics, May 2025, pp. 444–460.

[15] **Leveraging Language Models to Detect Greenwashing**
Avalon Vinella, Margaret Capetz, Rebecca Pattichis, **Christina Chance**, Reshmi Ghosh, and Kai-Wei Chang. 2024.

[16] **Survey of Bias In Text-to-Image Generation: Definition, Evaluation, and Mitigation**
Yixin Wan, Arjun Subramonian, Anaelia Ovalle, Zongyu Lin, Ashima Suvarna, **Christina Chance**, Hritik Bansal, Rebecca Pattichis, and Kai-Wei Chang. 2024.

Theses

[17] **Operationalizing Harm, Designing Support: Toward a Community-Centered Framework for Moderation and Fairness**
Christina Chance. MA thesis. Los Angeles, CA: University of California Los Angeles, May 2024.

[18] **Zoom Audio Transcription Accuracy for African American Vernacular English**
Christina Chance. Bachelors thesis. Atlanta, GA: Emory University, 2022.

AWARDS

- FAccT 2026 Doctoral Consortium. *Selected participant in the ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency doctoral consortium.*
- Outstanding Mentorship Award (Graduate Student), awarded by UCLA Computer Science 2026.
- GEM Fellow, awarded 2025 ($16k). *Nationally competitive fellowship supporting underrepresented minority students in STEM PhD programs.*
- Eugene V. Cota-Robles Fellow, awarded by UCLA 2022–27 (2AY of fellowship support, $60k). *Prestigious university-wide fellowship awarded to exceptional doctoral students from underrepresented backgrounds.*
- 100 Senior Honorary, awarded by Emory University 2022. *Recognizes the top 100 graduating seniors for academic and leadership excellence.*
- Computer Science Outstanding Student of the Year, awarded by Emory University 2022.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- **Collegium of University Teaching Fellows (CUTF)**, UCLA, 2026–2027
  - Designing and teaching an original undergraduate writing course, "AI, Power, and Society," offered for writing credit, on how AI systems exercise and reshape social and political power.
  - Drawing on social computing and digital ethnography, students learn to synthesize information across fields and apply NLP approaches to study the implications of these tools for social and political power.
- **UCLA TA Coordinator** (Appointed Year-Long), 2025–2026 & 2026–2027
  - Departmental appointment overseeing, mentoring, and supporting computer science teaching assistants, coordinating TA assignments and training.
  - Served as a liaison between TAs, instructors, and the department.
- **Teaching Assistant**, UCLA CS495 (TA Training Seminar), Fall 2025 & 2026 — Prof. Sandra Batista. Supported ∼75 students; graded assignments, provided feedback to new TAs, hosted office hours.
- **Teaching Assistant**, UCLA CS32 (Introduction to Computer Science II), Summer 2026 — Prof. Bruce Huang. Supported ∼180 students; led discussion sections, hosted office hours, and assisted in grading exams.
- **Teaching Assistant**, UCLA CS131 (Programming Languages), Winter 2025 & Spring 2025 — Prof. Paul Eggert. Led weekly discussion sections and managed exams for ∼120–180 students across two terms.
- **Ignite Fellow**, Teach for America, 2025
  - Selective fellowship placing fellows as virtual tutors and mentors for K-12 students in under-resourced schools, delivering supplemental instruction in core subjects.
- **Teaching Assistant**, UCLA CS180 (Introduction to Algorithms and Complexity), Fall 2024 — Prof. Alexis Korb & Prof. Glenn Reinman. Supported ∼240 students; led discussion sections and hosted office hours.
- **Teaching Assistant**, UCLA CS162 & CS263 (Natural Language Processing), Winter & Spring 2024 — Prof. Nanyun Peng. Helped create and grade assignments, exams, and course projects across ∼120–130 students per term.
- **Teaching Assistant**, UCLA CS30 (Principles and Practices of Computing), Fall 2023 — Prof. Todd Millstein. Supported ∼120 students.
- **Teaching Assistant**, Emory University CS377 (Database Systems), Spring 2022 — Prof. Nosayba El-Sayed. Supported ∼40 students.

INVITED TALKS & GUEST LECTURES

- **Invited Talk**, UCLA NLP Seminar, Fall 2026.
- **Invited Talk**, Wilfandel Club House, Los Angeles, 2026. "Black Futures in the Age of Artificial Intelligence: A Fireside Chat on AI, Innovation, Equity, & Community" Community talk to an audience of Black women on how emerging AI systems affect Black communities.
- **Guest Lecture**, Anthro 259: Ethnography in Technology, UCLA, 2026. On the failure modes of large language models that disproportionately affect marginalized communities and their relation to content moderation.
- **Guest Instructor**, Hartford Youth Scholars, 2026. Designed and taught "Introduction to Computational Art," a short introductory course for middle school students.
- **Invited Talk**, MARS Lab (Prof. Saadia Gabriel), UCLA, 2024. Presented preliminary work on IYKYK and on bias in AAVE emotion detection, alongside an overview of related research.
- **Invited Talk**, USC ISI Fairness and Bias Seminar, 2024. Presented preliminary findings from IYKYK.

SERVICE

- Program Committee/Reviewer: AIES 2025, 2026; FAccT 2026; ARR Feb. 2025; TrustNLP 2024, 2025
- UCLA Student Conduct Committee Member, 2024–Present
  - Sit on panels reviewing student conduct cases and deciding whether a student has violated the code of conduct.
- UCLA Student Fee Advisory Committee (SFAC) Member, 2024–2026 & Chair, 2026–Present
  - Student-majority committee recognized by Regents Policy 3101 that advises the Chancellor on allocating the Student Services Fee across student-facing units and programs.
  - Oversee a roughly $2M student fee budget, review unit usage of student fee funds through unit reviews, and make recommendations on course material fees, referenda, and other campus fees.
- Computer Science Graduate Students Association at UCLA Executive Board Member, 2024–Present.
- Graduate Women in Computer Science at UCLA Treasurer & Executive Board Member, 2022–Present.
- Black Graduate Students Association at UCLA Historian & Treasurer, 2022–Present.
- Grad STRIVE 2.0 Grad2Grad Mentor, 2024–2025.
- ACM FAccT 2024 Craft Organizer of In Código of Hope: Possibilities of Global Solidarity and Activism in Academic Environments.
- UCLA Computer Science Summer Institute 2024 Introductory & Intermediate Program Coordinator.
- Institute for African-American Mentoring in Computing Sciences Mentor, 2023–2024.
- ACM SIGKDD KDD 2023 Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion Day Workshop Co-Organizer and Panelist.
- ACM FAccT 2023 Volunteer.
- Black & Latinx in STEM (BLIS) at Emory University, Co-Founder and President, 2019–2022
  - Created a space for Black and brown STEM students to build community, learn about research opportunities, receive mentorship, and explore careers in the field.

- Partnered with the undergraduate research program and IMSD, and established a faculty mentorship board that advocated for the organization and its students.

SKILLS

Programming	Python (advanced) SQL, Java, R (proficient) PHP, MATLAB, HTML (basic)